

Six Thinking Hats

Argument vs. Parallel Thinking

Six Thinking Hats

Framework

- Confusion is the biggest enemy of good thinking
 - We try to do too many things at a time
 - Juggling with six balls at a time is rather difficult
 - Tossing up one ball at a time is much easier
 - Six Hat Thinking does one thing at a time and in the end the full picture emerges

Six Thinking Hats

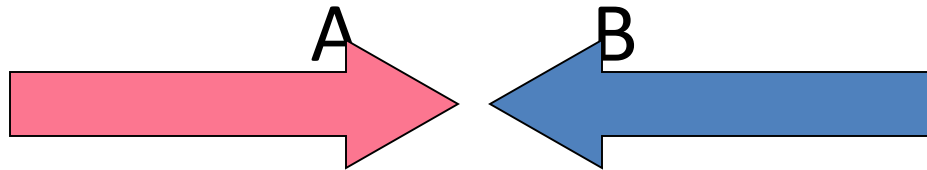
Western Thinking = Argument

- Western thinking was designed about 2300 years ago by the Greek "Gang of Three":
 - Socrates - simply point out what is "wrong"
 - Plato - we see only shadow "truths"
 - Aristotle - things fit into "boxes" (categories)
- Western thinking is concerned with "what is" determined by analysis, judgment and argument.

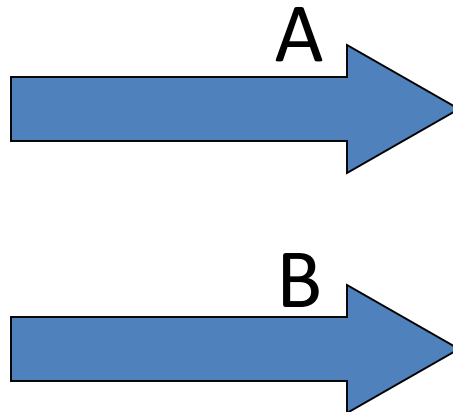
Six Thinking Hats

Adversarial vs. Parallel Thinking

Adversarial Thinking



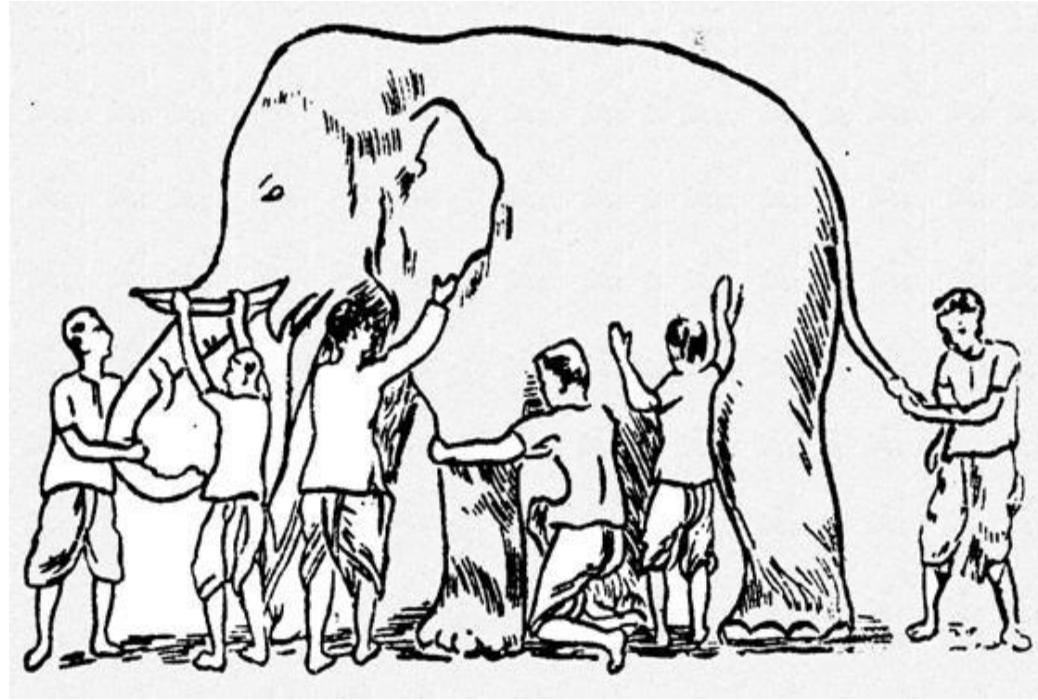
Parallel Thinking



Six Thinking Hats

Parallel Thinking

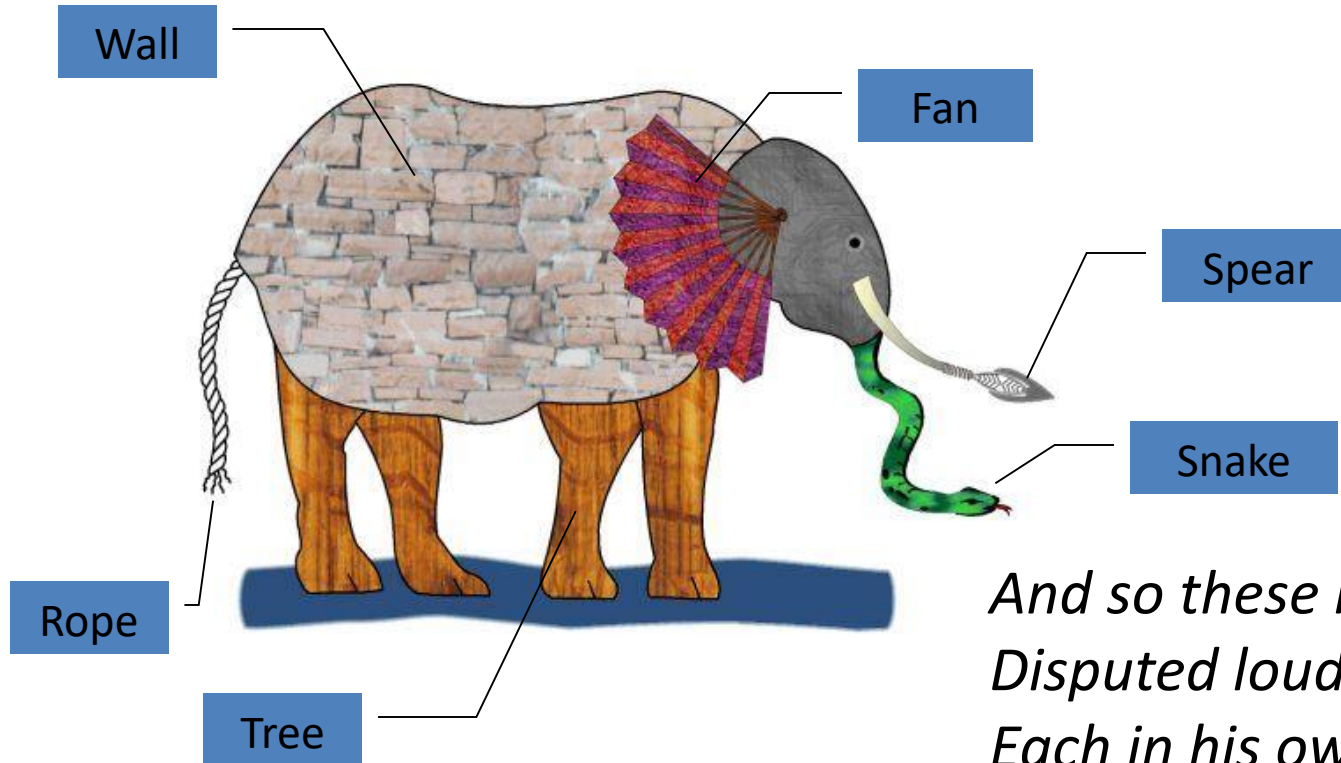
*It was six men much
inclined To learning,
Who went to see the
Elephant
(Though all of them
were blind),
That each by
observation
Might satisfy his mind.*



John Godfrey Saxe's (1816-1887) version of
the famous Indian legend

Six Thinking Hats

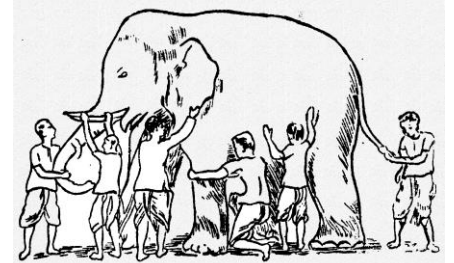
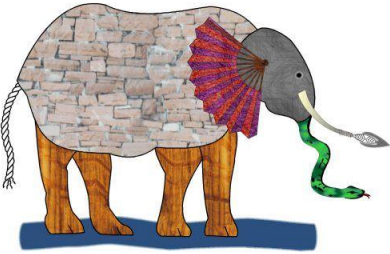
Parallel Thinking



*And so these men of Indostan
Disputed loud and long,
Each in his own opinion
Exceeding stiff and strong,
Though each was partly in the
right,
And all were in the wrong!*

Six Thinking Hats

Parallel Thinking



A wise man was passing by and he saw this. He stopped and asked them, "What is the matter?" They said, "We cannot agree to what the elephant is like."

The wise man calmly explained to them, "All of you are right. The reason every one of you is telling it differently is because each one of you touched a different part of the elephant. So, actually the elephant has all those features."

"Oh!" everyone said. There was no more fight. They felt happy that they were all right.

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Parallel Thinking

- Using parallel thinking they could all walk around and “look” at each part of the elephant together. So at each moment each person is looking in parallel from the same point of view and in the same direction.
- This is almost the exact opposite of argument, adversarial, confrontational thinking
 - Each party deliberately takes an opposite view
 - Each tries to prove the other wrong

Six Thinking Hats

Directions and Hats

- By using standard labels (like: front, back, left side, right side, north, south, east, west) we can choose which direction we want to look.
- What are the different directions thinkers can be invited to look?
- This is where the hats come in:
 - There are six colored hats corresponding to the six directions of thinking: white, red, black, yellow, green, blue.
- Why hats?
 - A hat indicates a role (i.e. I see you have your thinking cap on...)
 - A hat can be put on or taken off with ease
 - A hat is visible to everyone around

Six Thinking Hats

The Six Hats



Six Thinking Hats



The WHITE Hat = Facts and Data

- The **White Hat** calls for information known or needed.
 - Think of white paper, which is neutral and carries information:
 - ...What information do we have?
 - ...What information is missing?
 - ...What information would we like to have?
 - ...How are we going to get missing information?

When you are asked for **White Hat** thinking, you are being asked to put aside proposals and arguments - and to focus directly on the information.



Six Thinking Hats

The RED Hat = Feelings / Intuition

- The **Red Hat** signifies feelings, hunches, and intuition.
 - Think of red and fire and warm:
 - ...Putting on my **red hat**, this is what I feel about the project
 - ...My gut feel is that it will not work
 - ...I don't like the way this is being done

Because the **Red Hat** signals feelings, they can come into the discussion without pretending to be anything else.



Six Thinking Hats

The BLACK Hat = Issues / Concerns

- The **Black Hat** is judgment - the devil's advocate or why something may not work.
 - Think of a stern judge wearing black robes who comes down heavy on wrong-doers.
 - The **Black Hat** is the caution hat.
 - ...The regulations do not permit us to do that
 - ...We do not have the capacity to meet the demand

The **Black Hat** is very valuable but overuse can be a problem.



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The Yellow Hat = Benefits

- The **Yellow Hat** symbolizes brightness and optimism.
 - Think of sunshine.
 - The **Yellow Hat** is for:
 - The logical positive view of things
 - Feasibility and how something can be done
 - Benefits that are logically based:
 - ...This might work if we moved the plant nearer the customers

Yellow Hat thinking requires a deliberate effort. Benefits are not always immediately obvious and we might have to search for them.



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The GREEN Hat = New ideas / Possibilities

- The **Green Hat** focuses on creativity; the possibilities, alternatives, and new ideas.
 - Think of vegetation and rich growth.
 - The **Green Hat** is for:
 - New ideas and additional alternatives
 - Putting forward possibilities and hypotheses
 - Creative efforts
 - ...We need some new ideas here
 - ...Could we do this a different way?

The **Green Hat** makes time and space available for creative thinking.



Six Thinking Hats

The BLUE Hat = Managing the Thinking

- The **Blue Hat** is used to manage the thinking process.
 - Think of the sky and an overview.
 - The **Blue Hat**:
 - Is for process control
 - Sets the agenda for thinking
 - Suggests the next step in the thinking
 - Can ask for other hats:
 - ...I suggest we try some green hat thinking
 - ...Could we have a summary of your views?

The **Blue Hat** is for thinking about thinking. It is used for organizing and controlling the process so that it becomes more productive.

Six Thinking Hats

Framework

- Encourages parallel thinking
- Directs thinking in discrete segments
- Switches thinking from one mode to another
- Explores a subject more thoroughly
- Makes specific time and space for creative thinking
- Separates ego from performance

Six Thinking Hats



- **White Hat:** Looks objectively at data and information. Is neutral and concerned with facts and figures.



- **Red Hat:** Legitimizes feelings and gives an emotional view, hunches, and intuition.



- **Yellow Hat:** Is positive and constructive. The yellow color symbolizes sunshine, brightness and optimism.



- **Black Hat:** Is logical, negative, judgmental, and cautious. Is gloomy, suggests why it cannot be done.



- **Green Hat:** Is about new ideas and creative thinking.



- **Blue Hat:** Controls the thinking process. The blue hat is concerned with control and the organization of the thinking process.



Six Thinking Hats

White Hat:

Information

- 🎩 Information we know
- 🎩 Information we would like to know
- 🎩 Information we need
- 🎩 Information that is missing
- 🎩 How are we going to get that information
- 🎩 Includes hard facts to doubtful information

Red Hat:



Feelings, Intuition, Emotions

- 🎩 Permission to express feelings
- 🎩 No need to justify
- 🎩 Represents feelings right now
- 🎩 Keep it short
- 🎩 A key ingredient in decision making

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Black Hat:

Logical Negative

- 🎩 The pessimistic view
- 🎩 Reasons must be given
- 🎩 Points out thinking that does not fit the facts, experience, regulations, strategy, values
- 🎩 Points out potential problems



Yellow Hat:

Logical Positive

- 🎩 The optimistic view
- 🎩 Reasons must be given
- 🎩 Needs more effort than the black hat
- 🎩 Looks for the concept behind the idea

Six Thinking Hats



Green Hat:

*New Ideas,
Possibilities*

- 🎩 Creative thinking
- 🎩 Seeking alternatives and possibilities
- 🎩 Removing faults
- 🎩 Doesn't have to be logical
- 🎩 Generates new concepts



Blue Hat:

Managing the Thinking

- 🎩 "Control" hat
- 🎩 Organizes the thinking
- 🎩 Sets the focus and agenda
- 🎩 Summarizes and concludes
- 🎩 Ensures that the rules are observed